HANKIE-PANKY



Trust Tamil Nadu politics to turn a hankie into a headline. A clip of AIADMK chief **Edappadi K. Palaniswami**, looking sorry and with a kerchief over his face after a meeting with the BJP's Amit Shah, went viral in no time. Social media had a field day. A livid EPS hit back, saying he was merely wiping the sweat off, and even taunted the media for "its new low". His party followed up with a legal notice to a journalist. But the kerchief kerfuffle refused to die quietly, fluttering on through opposition jibes and breaking headlines.

BIRTHDAY BASHING



BJP MP and Rajasthan in-charge **Radha Mohan Das Agrawal** lost his cool recently at the Jaipur workshop to plan the 'Sewa Pakhwada', the fortnight-long celebration of PM Modi's 75th birthday. Angered by the thin turnout, he thundered that "nobody was taking it seriously" and stormed out. A panicked MoS for home, Jawahar Singh Bedam, chased after his car to try and persuade him to stay till CM Bhajan Lal Sharma arrived. But to no avail. Insiders say Agrawal's impatience reflects a larger unease: ministers complain they are overburdened with party/RSS programmes, while party workers accuse them of ignoring their demands.

WHO PAYS FOR LAST RESPECTS?



Politics doesn't end with life, sometimes it continues even after death. A row has erupted over the Rs 25 lakh spent on former Gujarat chief minister **Vijay Rupani**'s farewell procession in Rajkot after he died in the Air India crash in June. Vendors supplying flowers, tents and other services were reportedly turned away by BJP functionaries and told to approach the Rupani family for payment. The party eventually settled the bills, but many saw it as a sign of disrespect to the late leader.

Kaushik Deka with Avaneesh Mishra, Jeemon Jacob, Rohit Parihar, Kavitha Muralidharan and Jumana Shah

ECO WATCH

By **Jumana Shah**

SAVE THE WHALE SHARK
CUT NETS, GET A REWARD

On August 30, the Wildlife Trust of India (WTI), in partnership with the Goa forest department, department of fisheries, and Oracle India, launched the Whale Shark Conservation Project in Goa, coinciding with International Whale Shark Day. The initiative, aimed at protecting the endangered whale shark (*Rhincodon typus*), builds on WTI's successful models in Gujarat and Kerala, integrating local communities to safeguard India's marine biodiversity.



The Goa project has the highest compensation scheme, offering Rs 75,000 to fishermen who cut nets to free entangled whale sharks or other Schedule I marine species, surpassing Gujarat and Kerala's Rs 50,000 cap. Additionally, India's first dedicated marine conservation vessel will enhance rescue operations and research. Local fisherman Francis Fernandes (Pele) leads efforts to educate Goa's fishing community.

In Gujarat, WTI's 2004 campaign transformed whale sharks from hunted "*vhali*" to revered "*vhail ma*" (dear mother). Over 1,000 rescues have been recorded. Awareness campaigns, photo-identification and satellite tagging have bolstered conservation. In Kerala, similar efforts since 2011 have yielded over 300 saves. In 2017, the project expanded to Lakshadweep, the second-largest aggregation site in India after Gujarat. With help from Cochin Shipyard Ltd, the project has rescued and released 46 whale sharks so far.